BARD SUBCLASS · D&D 2024

College of the Nightmare Troupe

A performer of a traveling troupe who dances through scarlet fire, vanishes when struck, and raises a hungry flame-child that grows with the Ritual.

V0.1 PLAYTEST BARD LEVELS 3–14 INSPIRED BY HOLLOW KNIGHT

When the Nightmare Lantern is lit, the Troupe arrives: tents of scarlet cloth, music in the dark, and a master who dances in fire. Their performances feed an ancient Ritual, a cycle that has turned for longer than any kingdom has stood. Bards of this college have joined the Troupe. They carry a Grimmchild, a newborn flame that feeds on the Ritual and grows as it does. Every member knows that one day the cycle will ask them to choose: carry the Ritual forward, or play the song that ends it.

BARD LEVEL	FEATURES
3rd	Troupe Flame, Grimmchild, Vanishing Act
6th	Grimmchild Grows, Pillar Dance, The Troupe's Tent
14th	The Ritual's End (Nightmare Heart or Carefree Melody)

LEVEL 3

Troupe Flame

You know the *Fire Bolt* cantrip. It doesn't count against the number of cantrips you know, and it's a Bard spell for you.

LEVEL 3

Grimmchild

A small, hungry flame creature from the Troupe follows you, waiting to grow. It uses the Grimmchild stat block below, acts during your turn, and obeys your commands. Unless you take a Bonus Action to command it to take a different action, it takes the Dodge action.

Kindred Flame. Once per turn, when you cast *Fire Bolt*, Grimmchild can also make an Ember Shot without needing a command.

Return to the Troupe. If Grimmchild dies, its flame returns to the Troupe. It reappears at the end of your next Long Rest, or sooner if you take a Magic action and expend a spell slot of level 1 or higher.

Grimmchild

Tiny Monstrosity

AC	HP	SPEED
13 + your Proficiency Bonus	5 × your Bard level	10 ft., Fly 40 ft. (hover)

Immunities: Fire. **Senses:** Darkvision 60 ft. It sheds Dim Light in a 10-foot radius.

Ember Shot. *Ranged Attack Roll:* your spell attack modifier, range 60 ft. *Hit:* 1d6 + your Proficiency Bonus Fire damage.

LEVEL 3

Vanishing Act

When a creature you can see hits you with an attack, you can take a Reaction and expend one use of Bardic Inspiration to vanish in a burst of scarlet flame. You teleport up to 30 feet to an unoccupied space you can see. Each creature within 5 feet of the space you left takes Fire

damage equal to one roll of your Bardic Inspiration die.

LEVEL 6

Grimmchild Grows

Grimmchild's flame swells. Its Fly Speed becomes 50 feet, and Ember Shot deals 2d6 + your Proficiency Bonus Fire damage.

LEVEL 6

Pillar Dance

As a Bonus Action, you can expend one use of Bardic Inspiration to make a column of flame erupt at a point you can see within 60 feet: a cylinder 5 feet in radius and 20 feet high. Each creature in the column makes a Dexterity saving throw against your spell save DC, taking Fire damage equal to two rolls of your Bardic Inspiration die on a failed save or half as much on a success.

LEVEL 6

The Troupe's Tent

You can cast *Leomund's Tiny Hut* as a Ritual without preparing it. It appears as a scarlet circus tent. Each creature that finishes a Short Rest inside it can roll one extra Hit Point Die without expending it.

LEVEL 14

The Ritual's End

The Troupe Master has found you, and the cycle asks for your answer. Choose one of the following paths. Once chosen, it can't be changed.

Nightmare Heart (Continue the Ritual)

The cycle continues, and Grimmchild becomes the next Grimm.

- **Grown Flame.** Grimmchild becomes Small, and Ember Shot deals 3d6 + your Proficiency Bonus Fire damage.

- **Nightmare King.** As a Bonus Action, you become the Nightmare King for 1 minute. While transformed, Vanishing Act costs no Bardic Inspiration, your Fire damage ignores Resistance to Fire, and when you cast *Fire Bolt*, you can target two different creatures, making a separate attack roll for each. Once you use this feature, you can't do so again until you finish a Long Rest.

Carefree Melody (Banish the Troupe)

You play the song that sends the Troupe away. Grimmchild leaves you forever, and a gentler melody takes its place.

- **Carefree Melody.** When an attack hits you, roll a d10. On a 7 or higher, the attack deals no damage to you. Each time the roll fails, the number you need drops by 1 for your next roll (minimum 2); it resets to 7 after a success.
- **Lingering Song.** When you roll Initiative, you regain one expended use of Bardic Inspiration. A creature that uses one of your Bardic Inspiration dice also gains Temporary Hit Points equal to your Charisma modifier.

OPTIONAL RULE

The Ritual

Instead of Grimmchild growing at Bard levels 6 and 14, the DM can tie its growth to the story. The party must gather Scarlet Flames from lanterns across the world, each guarded by Grimmkin. Grimmchild grows when it has eaten enough flames, and the Troupe Master arrives for the final choice when the last flame is claimed.

Running a campaign below Dirtmouth? The Hallownest setting sketch places the Nightmare Lantern there.

DESIGNER NOTES

- **Lore in the mechanics.** Vanishing Act is Grimm's teleport, Pillar Dance is his flame pillars, the Tent is the Troupe's camp, and the 14th-level choice mirrors the game's ending choice: continue the Ritual or banish the Troupe with Brumm's song.
- **Bonus Action pressure.** Commanding Grimmchild, Pillar Dance, and giving Bardic Inspiration all want the Bonus Action. Kindred Flame lets Grimmchild attack without one.

- **Carefree Melody** recreates the charm's escalating block chance: each failed roll makes the next one likelier.
- Is Grimmchild's Hit Point total (5 × Bard level) too high for a free companion?
- Is Carefree Melody's escalating block too strong at the capstone, or too swingy?
- Room for more lore: Flame Bats, Grimm's bow, Brumm's accordion, and the Nightmare Lantern?

V0.1 PLAYTEST: FIRST PUBLIC RELEASE

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